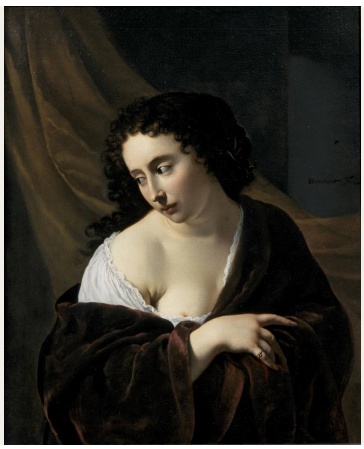
UTRECHT, NETHERLANDS

Centraal Museum: Masterpieces

Utrecht's formal self-image meets the movement of streets, workshops and a night fair.



A city portrait can make buildings and offices appear permanent. A passing group of pedestrians gives a different account of urban life: people occupy the same street only briefly, and the image must decide what to retain. This selection brings those approaches together, from elevated views of Utrecht's fortifications to Isaac Israëls's quickly articulated scenes of work and leisure.

The useful contrast is not simply between old and new. Carefully arranged still lifes turn abundance into a public display, while a reader or seated boxer interrupts the demand for action. Notice when a painting asks someone to pose and when it gives attention to a person already occupied with something else.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/centraal-museum

The selection · 20

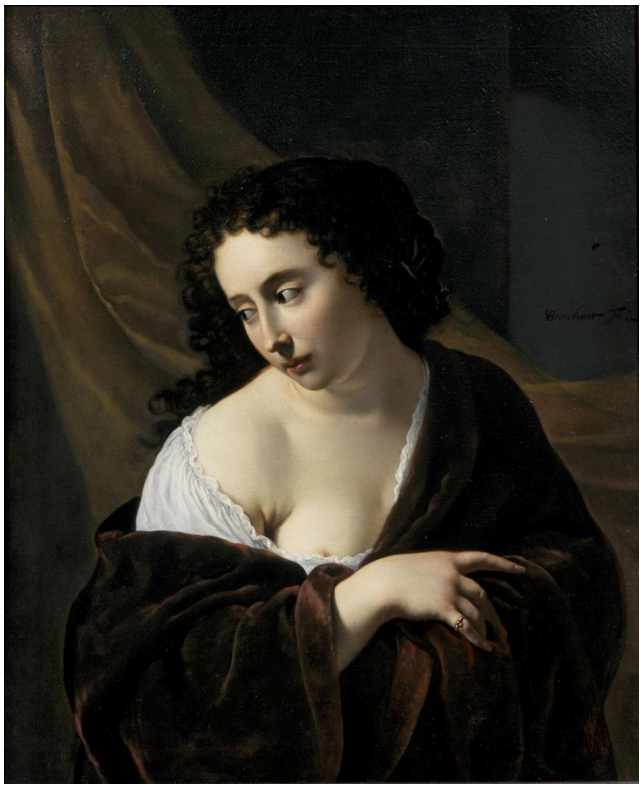
1. A Young Woman
   Johannes Jansz Bronckhorst · 1654
2. Heraclitus
   Johannes Moreelse · 1630
3. Vredenburg Castle in Utrecht
   Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh · 1660
4. The Oudegracht in Utrecht
   Hendrik van Oort · 1838
5. The Pausdam and Achter de Dom, Utrecht
   Hendrik van Oort · 1820
6. The Tolsteeg Gate and Its Surroundings, Utrecht
   Hendrik van Oort · c. 1830
7. The Weerd Gate and Its Surroundings, Utrecht
   Bruno van Straaten · c. 1830
8. The Adoration of the Shepherds
   Johan de Veer · c. 1650
9. The Burgomasters of Utrecht with the City Messengers
   Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh · 1658
10. The Raising of Lazarus
    Aert Jansz Marienhof · 1648
11. The City Banner of Utrecht
    Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh · 1658
12. Aleida Gijsberta van Ogtrop-Hanlo with Her Five Children
    Thérèse Schwartze · 1906
13. Sewing School
    Isaac Israëls · c. 1905–c. 1906
14. The Rainbow
    William Degouve de Nuncques · c. 1910
15. Factory Girls on the Prinsengracht, Amsterdam
    Isaac Israëls · 1894
16. The Black Boxer
    Isaac Israëls · 1914
17. Steam Carousel at Night
    Isaac Israëls · 1910
18. Still Life with Fruit and Lobster
    Michiel (II) Simons · c. 1670
19. Fish Still Life and Seascape
    Willem Ormea · 1641
20. Reading Girl
    Isaac Israëls · c. 1920

01 / 20

A Young Woman

Johannes Jansz Bronckhorst

1654 · Centraal Museum



Johannes Jansz Bronckhorst. A young woman. Image credit: Johannes Jansz Bronckhorst. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The hand resting across the wrap helps locate the body beneath the loose material. Above it, the inclined head continues a movement rather than standing as an isolated face. Bronckhorst needs little setting to make the pose coherent. The relationship between hand, garment and head supplies the structure that a more formal portrait might obtain from furniture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 15008

02 / 20

Heraclitus

Johannes Moreelse

1630 · Centraal Museum



Johannes Moreelse. Heraclitus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The globe gives this bent, elderly figure something larger than his own circumstances to contemplate. Moreelse places the emphasis on clasped hands and the lit surfaces of age, making thought take a bodily form. This is a constructed image of a philosopher, not a record of an observed ancient sitter; the expression belongs to that act of characterisation.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Vredenburg Castle in Utrecht

Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh

1660 · Centraal Museum



Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh. Castle Vredenburg in Utrecht. Image credit: Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

From this elevated position, walls, towers and surrounding water can be understood together. A person approaching at ground level could not take in the complex so readily. Van Swanenburgh trades the experience of arrival for an explanatory view. The image shows how painting can reconstruct a city's shape, while remaining a designed account rather than a transparent map.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 12645 a

04 / 20

The Oudegracht in Utrecht

Hendrik van Oort

1838 · Centraal Museum



Hendrik van Oort. De Oudegracht te Utrecht. Image credit: Hendrik van Oort. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The bridge divides the view into levels: people stand above the canal and closer to the water below. Through its arch, another crossing extends the route. Van Oort makes the engineering of the city intelligible through its use. Small figures are valuable here because their different positions reveal how inhabitants move through an uneven built space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2331

05 / 20

The Pausdam and Achter de Dom, Utrecht

Hendrik van Oort

1820 · Centraal Museum



Hendrik van Oort. De Pausdam and Achter de Dom in Utrecht. Image credit: Hendrik van Oort. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The cart and pedestrians occupy a comparatively narrow strip beneath the tall façades. Their scale makes the street feel inhabited without reducing the buildings to scenery. Irregular roofs prevent a uniform architectural rhythm. Van Oort's view lets the city retain both its imposing vertical presence and the ordinary traffic that passes along its base.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2333

06 / 20

The Tolsteeg Gate and Its Surroundings, Utrecht

Hendrik van Oort

c. 1830 · Centraal Museum



Hendrik van Oort. De Tolsteegpoort en omgeving te Utrecht. Image credit: Hendrik van Oort. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Frozen water changes the city's usable space. What ordinarily separates the gate and its surroundings becomes a surface for walkers and skaters. The solid skyline of walls and windmill remains, but the activities below it belong to a temporary condition. Reading the figures against the architecture reveals a boundary briefly put to another purpose.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2332

07 / 20

The Weerd Gate and Its Surroundings, Utrecht

Bruno van Straaten

c. 1830 · Centraal Museum



Bruno van Straaten. De Weerdpoort met omgeving te Utrecht. Image credit: Bruno van Straaten. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Water supplies a broad approach to the buildings, and the changing sizes of the boats make that distance readable. A bright sail catches attention before the eye reaches the shore. Van Straaten presents the city through movement towards it, a different relationship from the elevated overview of Vredenburg Castle, where the whole complex can be surveyed at once.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2304

08 / 20

The Adoration of the Shepherds

Johan de Veer

c. 1650 · Centraal Museum



Johan de Veer. De aanbidding van de herders. Image credit: Johan de Veer. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The infant occupies little space yet receives the converging attention of the group. Heads and hands determine the centre more effectively than size could. Johan de Veer keeps the gathering close, with shadow limiting its edges. Compare the civic portraits: a figure can command a composition through the behaviour of others rather than through rank and dress.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2280

09 / 20

The Burgomasters of Utrecht with the City Messengers

Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh

1658 · Centraal Museum



Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh. De burgemeesters van Utrecht met de stadsboden. Image credit: Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Clothing differentiates the officials and messengers before their faces are considered individually. The tiled setting gives their positions a common order, and the opening connects that order to the city outside. Van Swanenburgh represents a public structure as a gathering of bodies. The portrait records distinctions of office as deliberately as it records likenesses.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1537

10 / 20

The Raising of Lazarus

Aert Jansz Marienhof

1648 · Centraal Museum



Aert Jansz Marienhof. De opwekking van Lazarus. Image credit: Aert Jansz Marienhof. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Lazarus's emergence is an event that has to be witnessed. Marienhof gives the surrounding figures enough room for their responses to remain distinguishable, while the rocky setting contains them within a shared scene. The painting's action therefore extends beyond the revived body. The miracle becomes legible through the relationship between Christ, the tomb and those gathered around it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 7288

11 / 20

The City Banner of Utrecht

Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh

1658 · Centraal Museum



Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh. De stadsbanier van Utrecht. Image credit: Willem Cornelisz. van Swanenburgh. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The banner's broad red-and-white division is easier to grasp than the more complicated bodies and weapons underneath. That difference gives the civic emblem priority. The armoured figures make its support visible and physical. Van Swanenburgh connects an abstract identifying pattern to the people charged with carrying or defending it, rather than leaving it as a detached sign.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1536

12 / 20

Aleida Gijsberta van Ogtrop-Hanlo with Her Five Children

Thérèse Schwartze

1906 · Centraal Museum



Thérèse Schwartze. Portrait of Aleida Gijsberta Van Ogtrop Hanlo with Her Five Children. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Schwartze has to make six people belong together without giving them a single expression or pose. The close arrangement supplies cohesion, while different heights and glances keep the children distinct. Elaborate clothing contributes to the family's presentation, but the faces resist becoming a repeated pattern. Formal display and the practical problem of grouping a family remain visible together.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Sewing School

Isaac Israëls

c. 1905–c. 1906 · Centraal Museum



Isaac Israëls. Sewing school. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/isaac-israels/sewing-school-1906 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The women share a task rather than a pose. Their bent heads recur along the table, and pale fabric connects one working place to the next. Israëls's loose handling allows the repetition to remain irregular. The scene can be read as a collective activity without assuming that every worker is interchangeable or that concentration has only one appearance.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

The Rainbow

William Degouve de Nuncques

c. 1910 · Centraal Museum



William Degouve de Nuncques. L'arc en ciel. Image credit: William Degouve de Nuncques; Source credit: https://www.centraalmuseum.nl/nl/collectie/22147-larc-en-ciel-william-degouve-de-nuncques. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The fields and rows of trees divide the land into enduring patterns. The rainbow crosses those divisions without belonging to them. Degouve de Nuncques places a short-lived effect against an ordered landscape, making two kinds of duration visible together. Dark clouds help the arc register; there is no need to decide that the weather must encode a private emotion.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 22147

15 / 20

Factory Girls on the Prinsengracht, Amsterdam

Isaac Israëls

1894 · Centraal Museum



Isaac Israëls. Factory girls on the Prinsengracht in Amsterdam. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/isaac-israels/factory-girls-on-the-prinsengracht-in-amsterdam-1894 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The women remain a group through their shared pace and proximity, not through looking towards a painter. Israëls keeps the surrounding street active while giving these pedestrians the centre. Compare Schwartze's family: here connection has to be caught during movement. The picture lends passing figures the attention that a formal portrait reserves for people who have stopped.

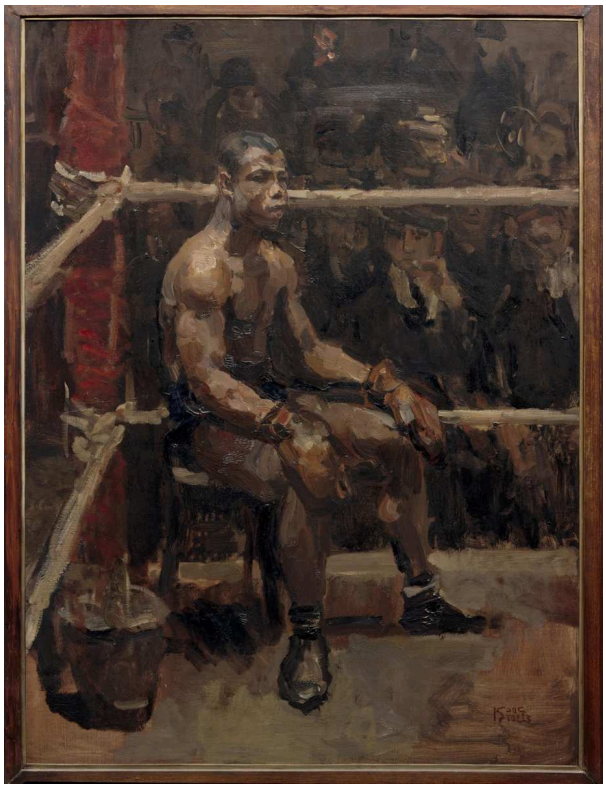
Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Black Boxer

Isaac Israëls

1914 · Centraal Museum



Isaac Israëls. The Black Boxer. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/isaac-israels/the-black-boxer-1914 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The ropes identify the setting, but the athlete is seated rather than fighting. Light and the turn of his body establish a substantial presence within the crowded interior. Israëls leaves the spectacle suspended. The pause offers a different subject from victory or defeat: a trained body at rest, without enough evidence to assign it a particular private thought.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Steam Carousel at Night

Isaac Israëls

1910 · Centraal Museum



Isaac Israëls. Steam carousel at night. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/isaac-israels/steam-carousel-at-night-1910 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The bright machinery and gathered crowd compete for visibility. Israëls lets small touches of light disclose portions of people rather than separating every face into a complete portrait. Recognition comes in fragments, much as attention at a crowded fair does. The handling serves the subject's congestion; it is not simply a quicker way to finish describing everything.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Still Life with Fruit and Lobster

Michiel (II) Simons

c. 1670 · Centraal Museum



Michiel (II) Simons. Still life with fruits and lobster. Image credit: Michiel (II) Simons. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The table presents plenty, but that plenty has been carefully distributed. Fruit skins, the lobster's shell and darker vessels offer different responses to light. Michiel Simons gives the eye reasons to pause at individual surfaces instead of reading the whole as an undifferentiated heap. The table edge remains a restraint on the abundance that seems to spread towards it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 6570

19 / 20

Fish Still Life and Seascape

Willem Ormea

1641 · Centraal Museum



Willem Ormea. Visstilleven en zeegezicht. Image credit: Willem Ormea. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The large fish belong to the near ledge; the tiny boats occupy a distant stretch of water. Ormea brings catch and sea into the same image without giving them the same scale or kind of attention. The abrupt transition is its organising device. An object examined closely can coexist with the place from which such objects come.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2325

20 / 20

Reading Girl

Isaac Israëls

c. 1920 · Centraal Museum



Isaac Israëls. Reading girl. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/isaac-israels/reading-girl-1920 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The book occupies little of the picture but organises the reader's entire pose. Furnishings and pictures remain loosely active around her, so absorption does not require an empty setting. Israëls differentiates the subject's attention from the viewer's: she stays with the page while the eye can wander through a room that continues beyond her immediate concern.

Object source · Open artwork

Return to the street

After the portraits, revisit one of the Utrecht views and notice what the small figures contribute. Without them, distances and uses become less clear. This guide follows selected collection records, not a fixed exhibition layout; consult the museum's current programme before planning to see particular works.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Harold Speed's The Practice and Science of Drawing discusses line, mass and the organization of a figure. Its practical vocabulary is useful when comparing the carefully posed portraits with Israëls's more rapidly painted bodies.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
